LESSONS IN CHANGE

ACCOMPLISHMENT
As the woman behind the Akanksha Foundation and Teach for India, Shaheen Mistri's sole aim for three decades now has been to bring quality education to every child

GROWING UP ACROSS FIVE DIFFERENT countries can change the way you look and engage with the world. For Shaheen Mistri, then an 18-year-old college student from the US who was visiting India in 1989 during her summer break and volunteering across slums in Mumbai, that experience came with a rather unsettling revelation—that the difference between herself and millions of other children who didn't have the same resources as her was more than just an accident of birth. It was systemic inequality entrenched so deep that change could only begin ground-up. And so, that's what Shaheen did. With 15 children and a rented premises, she started an 'Akanksha centre' in Mumbai's Colaba in 1989 to conduct classes for kids from low-income families. That was 34 years ago. Today, her Akanksha Foundation runs 26 schools across Mumbai, Pune and Nagpur, and has impacted over 14,000 students.

Two decades after setting up Akanksha, in the summer of 2009, Shaheen also founded Teach for India, the Indian chapter of the global Teach for All network. The first cohort comprised 87 'fellows' who served as teachers in low-income schools for two years. The project has grown exponentially since then, impacting over 34,000 children through about 1,000 fellows across eight cities. The TFI alumni community is 4,200-plus members strong, and the organisation impacts one million children directly, and 50 million indirectly.

"The law of love is best learned from children", these words by Mahatma Gandhi, says Shaheen, sum up her fondness for children. "Having spent more than 30 years working alongside children, I strongly feel that our children have limitless potential, and that there is a need to treat them better. Even though the task of providing an excellent education to every single child is daunting and big, it is also joyful and full of hope and possibilities, because that's how our children view the world," she says. Challenges abound in that journey—bringing in funding, and cultivating a workforce that's passionate and driven even in the face of odds—but that's nothing compared to Shaheen's unflinching commitment to her cause. ■

–Shelly Anand

PRACTICE MAKES PERFECT

"Do what you believe in, and keep doing it until you become really good at it"



Shaheen Mistri, *52*
Founder, Teach for India and Akanksha Foundation

↘ A TOUGH CHOICE
Mistri loves animals. At one point, she even considered whether she wanted to work with children or for animals

↘ KEEPING IT LIGHT
When she finds herself free, Mistri likes to spend time with her loved ones and her dogs. She enjoys painting too